

gentlemen. They more likely resemble barracudas, who lie in wait and rely on surprise. Or perhaps Count Dracula, who will gladly suck you dry with nary a regret or backward glance. The days of trust have died, but we, the citizens, are the ones getting the stake pounded into our hearts.

It was not always this way. As recently as the 1970s, the American working citizen was treated with respect. Fair lending practices existed, and a banker was a trusted partner. A person could be granted overdraft protection on a checking account, simply by asking. It was a free courtesy granted to a good customer. A thirty-day free grace period to pay the balance was standard. But somewhere along the way, fairness went out of fashion. The terms “free” and “courtesy” have fallen out of the lending lexicon. Along came the 1980s, and the famous movie line from Gordon Gekko in *Wall Street*, “Greed is good,” announced the mindset of banks, corporations, and lending institutions. Greed became rampant and once it reared its ugly head, it became a wild beast to tame.

In the early days of loans and lending, the bank or mortgage company would give money in return for simple interest. Here’s my collateral; here’s my signature; and I received a loan. I repaid it within a certain timeframe, plus I paid a stated amount of interest. There were no hidden surprises and creatively-named fees. Then the annual percentage rate entered the picture. The scene then ushered in loan sharks and shylocks right out of Shakespeare’s *Merchant of Venice*, wanting to extract a pound of flesh and charging usury interest at exorbitant rates. The way some institutions deal with their customers today, a loan shark is a much better way to go.

The current method of fees on top of fees to keep a person tied up in debt their whole life, a prisoner to that debt, conjures up the days of the Dickens’ era debtor prisons. However, today’s lenders do not want us going to jail for not being able to pay our bills. They want us to keep working and therefore able to keep paying them month after month after month, while not reducing our debt at all. It truly is a crime.

Some states placed caps on the amount of interest that lenders could charge, but the banks and the credit card companies didn’t miss a beat. A new world of possibilities was born; for the rest of us, a new four-letter word had arrived: fees.